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SEBASTIAN WALTER

Abstract. This paper investigates whether emblematic gestures should be analyzed as expressive meaning contributions in the visual modality of spoken language. While formal-semantic work on gesture has primarily focused on iconic co-speech gestures, emblematic gestures have received comparatively little attention, despite their high degree of conventionalization and their ability to express speaker attitudes and entire communicative acts. Building on Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025), we first argue that emblematic gestures, unlike iconic gestures in general, satisfy the central diagnostics for expressive meaning proposed by Potts (2007): they are nondisplaceable, perspective-dependent, descriptively ineffable, immediate, and repeatable, while their independence from truth-conditional content is sensitive to alignment and differs across individual emblems. We then show that emblematic gestures do not form a homogeneous semantic class. Some emblems, such as THUMBS UP, behave like isolated expletive use-conditional items: they can occur independently of speech, do not require an argument from truth-conditional content, and allow comparatively flexible shifted interpretations. Other emblems, such as CRAZY, pattern with functional expletive use-conditional items: they are compositionally integrated, require an argument, and strongly favor speaker-oriented interpretations. We propose a formal analysis in $\mathcal{L}_{TV}$ that captures this distinction and argue that emblematic gestures provide evidence that expressivity is not restricted to the spoken modality.

1 Introduction

Expressive meaning provides a particularly revealing window into the interaction between language, affect, and speaker attitude. Expressions such as interjections, expressive adjectives, and epithets do not primarily serve to describe the world, but rather convey something about the speaker’s emotional state or evaluative stance. For instance, in (1), the epithet does not affect the truth conditions of the sentence, but contributes the speaker’s negative attitude toward Kresge.¹

(1) That bastard Kresge is famous.

(Potts, 2007)

Gestures, too, have often been described as revealing aspects of the speaker’s thoughts, emotions, and communicative intentions (e.g., Goldin-Meadow, 2005; Kendon, 2004; McNeill, 1992). In formal semantics, however, gesture research has so far primarily focused on how gestures contribute descriptive or not-at-issue content to spoken utterances, especially in the case of iconic co-speech gestures (e.g., Christian Ebert, Cornelia Ebert, and Hörnig, 2020; Cornelia Ebert and Christian Ebert, 2014; Esipova, 2019a; Schlenker, 2018a). By contrast, the relation between gesture and expressive meaning has received comparatively little systematic attention, the only two exceptions being Esipova (2019b) and Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025).

This gap is surprising, since some gestures seem to be natural candidates for expressive meaning. In particular, emblematic gestures such as THUMBS UP, MIDDLE FINGER, or CRAZY are highly conventionalized,

¹Some of the examples and gestures discussed in this paper involve offensive or derogatory content. This is not intended to endorse or reproduce such attitudes, but follows from the empirical domain under investigation, since expressive meaning often includes precisely such items. The figures depicting expressive gestures were generated with ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2025) in order to use a deliberately friendly-looking character and thereby soften potentially offensive effects of the visual material.

often convey speaker attitudes directly, and can sometimes constitute complete communicative acts on their own. These properties suggest that at least some gestures may function as visual counterparts of spoken-language expressives.²

The aim of this paper is to develop this idea in two steps. First, building on Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025), we argue that emblematic gestures, but not iconic gestures in general, satisfy the central diagnostics for expressive meaning proposed by Potts (2007). Second, we show that emblematic gestures do not form a homogeneous semantic class. Rather, different emblems pattern with different types of use-conditional items in the sense of Gutzmann (2015). More specifically, we argue that gestures such as THUMBS UP behave like isolated expletive use-conditional items, whereas gestures such as CRAZY pattern with functional expletive use-conditional items.

The remainder of this contribution is structured as follows: Section 2 introduces gesture types and discusses the special status of emblematic gestures, including earlier observations that they resemble interjections. Section 3 provides a brief overview of expressive meaning, introduces the diagnostics commonly used to identify expressive content, and subsequently applies these diagnostics to gestures. It concludes with the observation that there is a divide within the class of emblematic gestures: some seem to pattern with interjections, others exhibit behavior typically attested for expressive adjectives. Section 4 develops a formal analysis within a multidimensional framework. Section 5 concludes with open questions and directions for future research.

²This contribution focuses exclusively on visual expressives in spoken language. Expressive meaning in sign languages raises additional questions that fall outside the scope of the present paper (see Sutton-Spence and Napoli, 2025, for a recent overview on expressivity in sign languages).

2 Iconic vs. emblematic gestures

2.1 Iconic gestures

Iconic gestures are commonly defined as communicative movements that depict properties of objects, events, or spatial configurations by mapping aspects of their meaning onto the gesture space, thereby systematically adding meaning to the speech signal they co-occur with (e.g., Christian Ebert, Cornelia Ebert, and Hörnig, 2020; Kendon, 2004; Lücking, 2013; McNeill, 1986, 1992). Unlike arbitrary linguistic signs (Saussure, 1916), their interpretation is grounded in a resemblance relation between gestural form and conceptual content. For instance, a circular hand movement can be used to convey the round shape of an object:

(2) There is [a window] in my living room.³

ROUND

In (2), the gesture contributes information about the shape of the window. Crucially, however, this contribution is not fully specified by the gesture alone. Rather, iconic gestures are semantically underspecified and require integration with the co-occurring speech signal in order to yield a determinate interpretation (McNeill, 1992; Ruiter, 1998). This highlights the often-made observation about iconic gestures that they are not conventionalized (e.g., Kendon, 1988; McNeill, 1992, though see Ortega and Özyürek, 2020; Walter, Cornelia Ebert, and Hinterwimmer, 2025, for evidence and observations suggesting that also iconic gestures may, to some degree, be conventionalized).

Research in formal semantics argues that the temporal alignment of gesture and speech is a central factor governing the interpretation of iconic gestures. Most prominently, building on work reported in Fricke (2012), Cornelia Ebert and Christian Ebert (2014) claim that in the nominal domain, different alignment patterns result in different

³Square brackets in examples indicate temporal alignment of gesture and speech. Small caps are used to paraphrase the gesture in the line below.

interpretations of an iconic gesture (cf. Cornelia Ebert, Pirillo, and Walter, 2022, for experimental evidence in favor of this claim). When aligning the gesture with the entire DP, as in (2) above, this results in an interpretation where the gesture referent and the verbal referent must be similar in contextually relevant properties. By contrast, when aligning the gesture only with the NP, i.e., *window* in (2), this results in an exemplification reading, where the gesture referent merely depicts prototypical aspects of the verbal referent. Note, however, that both alignment patterns are cases where the gesture co-occurs with a part of speech. Following terminology introduced in Schlenker (2018b), this alignment pattern is commonly called *co-speech* in formal-semantic theory.

Many formal accounts of gesture semantics agree that co-speech gestures contribute not-at-issue meaning by default (Christian Ebert, Cornelia Ebert, and Hörnig, 2020; Cornelia Ebert and Christian Ebert, 2014; Schlenker, 2018a, though see, for example, Esipova, 2019a, for a different approach). At an intuitive level, not-at-issue content can be characterized as backgrounded meaning added on top of the asserted, or, at-issue, content of an utterance that does not carry the main theme of the current discourse (i.a. Potts, 2005; Simons et al., 2010; Tonhauser, 2012). This backgroundedness and special discourse status is linked to special properties of not-at-issue content, for example, that it projects, meaning that it cannot be targeted by negation and other semantic operators (Langendoen and Savin, 1971). While it is not the aim of this contribution to provide a formally and descriptively precise definition of at-issueness (though see Koev, 2018, for an overview), note that it plays a crucial role for the properties of expressive content as defined in Potts (2007), which will be stated in Section 3.2, where they will also be applied to emblematic and iconic gestures to check whether one gesture type qualifies as expressive content (cf. Cornelia Ebert and Walter, 2025).

Returning to different alignment of gesture and speech, Schlenker (2018b) identifies three further patterns: *pro-*, *post-*, and *pre-speech*, to which we will turn next.

of the speech signal, the more at-issue it becomes (cf. also Barnes and Cornelia Ebert, 2023). We will remain theory neutral throughout this paper regarding the meaning contribution of pre- and post-speech gestures, respectively, as the only thing we are concerned with here is the existence of the two alignment patterns.

Before turning to emblematic gestures, let us briefly summarize the characteristics of iconic gestures discussed in this section: they iconically depict properties of their referent and are semantically strongly underspecified, meaning that they must be integrated with the speech signal in order for their meaning to be fully derivable (see also Davidson, 2023, 2025, for recent discussions). Moreover, their interpretation, in particular their at-issue status, is sensitive to the different alignment patterns of gesture and speech. Following the terminology employed in Schlenker (2018b), we have identified co-, pro-, post-, and pre-speech alignments of gestures. Crucially, formal semantics has focused largely on co-speech gestures.

2.2 Emblematic gestures

While formal semantic research on co-speech gesture has predominantly focused on iconic gestures, emblematic gestures have received comparatively little attention. Apart from a few scattered remarks (MacFarlane, 2011, for remarks on their potential to make assertions and Esipova, 2019b, for remarks on their projective behavior), there is, to our knowledge, no systematic formal-semantic investigation of emblematic gestures. This gap is surprising, given that emblematic gestures differ fundamentally from iconic gestures in their degree of conventionalization and lexicalization (Kendon, 1988).

A useful starting point for capturing this contrast is Kendon's continuum (Kendon, 1988, 2004), which orders gestures according to their degree of conventionalization. Iconic gestures occupy the lower end of this scale, as their form–meaning mappings are highly context-dependent and underspecified. Emblematic gestures, by contrast, are highly conventionalized and culturally stabilized. As noted in Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025), this means that emblematic gestures such as

the ARTICHOKE, predominantly used in Italian-speaking communities (i.a. Ippolito, 2021; Kendon, 2004), THUMBSUP (cf. Figure 0.1), the VICTORY SIGN, or the MIDDLE FINGER (cf. Figure 0.2) have relatively fixed meanings within a speech community and can be interpreted independently of a specific linguistic context (Kendon, 1988, 2004). They thus share important features with words.

This difference in conventionalization has important theoretical consequences. Much of the existing formal work on gesture semantics relies on the depictive and context-sensitive nature of iconic gestures (e.g., Christian Ebert, Cornelia Ebert, and Hörnig, 2020; Schlenker, 2018a). However, these assumptions do not straightforwardly extend to emblematic gestures. Rather, emblems have been argued to behave more like lexical items, i.e., as conventionalized form–meaning pairings stored in a lexicon-like component (Kendon, 1988). This view is further supported by recent syntactic approaches (e.g., Colasanti,



Figure 0.1: The THUMBS UP gesture.



Figure 0.2: The MIDDLE FINGER gesture.

2023a,b; Colasanti and Marchetiello, 2026), which treat conventionalized gestures as fully integrated into the grammatical system in Italian dialects.

A further striking property of emblematic gestures is that they can express entire speech acts (cf. MacFarlane, 2011). Consider the examples in (5)–(7), adapted from Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025):

(5) A: Have you already eaten?

B: []
THUMBS UP

(6) I went to [the cinema] yesterday.

THUMBS UP

(7) I went to the cinema yesterday. []

THUMBS UP

Example (5) illustrates a *standalone pro-speech* use, where the emblem replaces speech entirely and conveys a meaning roughly paraphrasable as *Yes, and I liked it*. In (6) and (7), the gesture contributes an additional evaluative component (*I enjoyed it*) alongside the propositional content expressed in speech. Crucially, this contribution is not tightly integrated with the at-issue content of the utterance but rather constitutes an independent, additional meaning component (Cornelia Ebert and Walter, 2025).

Importantly, emblematic gestures occur across the full range of gesture–speech alignment patterns that have been identified above in Section 2.1 for iconic gestures already. While the examples in (5)–(7) illustrate occurrences of emblems in pro-, co-, and post-speech alignments respectively. A pre-speech occurrence of an emblem can be found in example (8) below.

- (8) [] I went to the cinema yesterday.
 THUMBS UP

While all alignment types are in principle available, emblematic gestures intuitively show a strong preference for pro-speech uses, in particular standalone pro-speech uses as in (5). This contrasts with iconic gestures, which are typically tightly integrated with speech and rarely occur as standalone utterances. As argued in Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025), this difference follows from the higher degree of conventionalization of emblems: since their meaning is semantically fixed, they do not depend on a linguistic host for interpretation.

This observation can be made more precise by considering the following contrast:

- (9) A: What kind of window is in the living room?
 B: #[]
 ROUND

- (10) A: How did you like the movie?
 B: []
 THUMBS UP

While the standalone use of an iconic gesture in (9) is degraded, the emblematic gesture in (10) constitutes a fully acceptable and sufficient answer. This supports the idea that emblematic gestures are lexically specified and can independently realize speech acts.

This property has led to the claim that emblematic gestures instantiate assertions (MacFarlane, 2011). However, such an analysis is not compatible with the view developed here. As will be argued below, we follow and extend the analysis defended in Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) that emblematic gestures do not contribute at-issue content in the sense of assertions but instead behave like expressive items in the sense of Potts (2005, 2007). This treatment stands in

direct opposition to a treatment of emblems as assertions, as they are normally assumed to carry at-issue content exclusively (e.g., Potts, 2005), but nevertheless allows us to argue that they may perform different types of speech acts.

Crucially, descriptive work on emblematic gestures already points in the direction that emblems contribute expressive meaning. In particular, Poggi (1983, 1987) argues that emblematic gestures share central properties with interjections: they are highly conventionalized, directly express speaker attitudes, and can constitute complete communicative acts on their own. This parallel is theoretically important, since interjections were among the first phenomena to receive a formal semantic treatment as expressive meaning (Kaplan, 1999; Potts, 2005).

Building on these observations, Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) argue that emblematic gestures should be analyzed as *visual expressives* of spoken language. The core idea is that, due to their high degree of conventionalization and lexicalization, emblematic gestures satisfy the central criteria for expressive meaning in the sense of Potts (2007), in contrast to iconic gestures, which generally do not. This claim is supported by systematically applying Potts’s diagnostics for expressivity to both gesture types and showing that only emblematic gestures consistently pattern with expressive items.

We will revisit this line of argument in a more condensed form in Section 3.2 below. However, the observations discussed in this section already point in the direction that emblematic gestures differ greatly from ionic gestures: they are lexically specified, can express entire speech acts, and are relatively independent of the propositional content of speech. They should thus also receive a different formal treatment, which is the main aim of the present paper.

This motivates the hypothesis that emblematic gestures are best analyzed as expressive meaning contributions in the visual modality. In the next section, we therefore turn to a more detailed discussion of expressive meaning. We will introduce the notion of expressivity, review the criteria proposed by Potts (2007), and apply them to

both iconic and emblematic gestures in order to make their semantic differences explicit.

3 Expressive meaning

3.1 Expressives in (formal) semantics

The notion of *expressivity* has long played a role in linguistic theorizing, although it has only relatively recently become the target of systematic formal investigation. Informally, expressivity can be understood as the property of language to directly express or display something about the speaker (cf. Gutzmann and Turgay, 2025). In this sense, expressive meaning contrasts with the default descriptive mode of communication, whose primary function is to convey information about the world rather than about the speaker.

The idea that language serves an expressive function is by no means new. In his *Organon model*, Bühler (1934) explicitly distinguishes an expressive function of language that mediates the relation between a linguistic sign and the speaker, capturing how utterances can reveal aspects of the speaker's internal state. Even earlier, Frege (1897/1979) introduces the notion of *coloring* to account for non-propositional aspects of meaning, such as meaning differences between expressions like *dog* and *cur*, which are seen as semantically and thus truth-conditionally equivalent but differ in their expressive content, thereby anticipating later distinctions between descriptive and expressive content.

At the same time, not every piece of information about the speaker that can be inferred from an utterance qualifies as expressive meaning in the technical sense. Any linguistic choice may reveal something about the speaker. For instance, taking an example from Gutzmann and Turgay (2025), when a speaker uses the term H_2O when speaking of *water*, this indicates that the speaker has specialized knowledge of water and is thus to some extent also expressive as it reveals information about the speaker. However, such information arises

via pragmatic inference and is not encoded in the lexical item itself. Therefore, we restrict our discussions of expressivity to cases where the relevant meaning contribution is part of the conventional semantics of an expression and constitutes (part of) its primary function. Only toward the end of this paper we will also briefly discuss cases where expressivity can be part of the non-conventionalized meaning of a gesture. Paradigmatic examples include interjections (cf. (11a)), expressive adjectives (cf. (11b)), and epithets (cf. (11c), Gutzmann and Turgay, 2025; Potts, 2005).

- (11) a. Ouch! I hit my thumb.
 b. That damn printer is broken again.
 c. That bastard Kresge is famous.

(Potts, 2007)

In these examples, the respective expressions (*ouch*, *damn*, *bastard*) do not contribute to the truth-conditional content of the utterance, but instead convey information about the speaker's emotional state or attitude. This has led to the widespread view that expressive meaning operates in a separate dimension from descriptive meaning that is entirely independent of the asserted, or at-issue, content, which is called the conventional-implicature (CI) dimension in Potts (2005).

A major starting point for the formal study of expressivity is Kaplan (1999), who argues that expressive expressions such as interjections cannot be analyzed in terms of truth conditions, but instead require a semantics in terms of *use conditions* (see also Recanati, 2004). On this view, the meaning of an expression like *oops* is not captured by specifying when it is true, but rather by specifying the conditions under which it can be felicitously used. This proposal has important consequences: if expressive meaning is governed by use conditions, then a purely truth-conditional semantics is insufficient to capture the full range of linguistic meaning.

At the same time, expressive and descriptive content can, in some cases, convey similar information while differing fundamentally in how this information is encoded. For instance, *oops* and *I observed a minor mishap* may be used to describe the same event, but the former conveys this information in an expressive mode, directly signaling the speaker's attitude toward the observed mishap, whereas the latter does so descriptively (Kaplan, 1999). Put differently, expressivity is not primarily about what is communicated, but rather about how it is communicated.

Taken together, we characterize expressive meaning in the narrow sense as i) being conventionally encoded, ii) conveying information about the speaker, typically their emotional state or attitude, and iii) operating largely independent of the truth-conditional core of the utterance. Importantly, this characterization remains at a relatively general level. While it allows us to distinguish expressive from non-expressive meaning in broad terms, it does not yet provide a precise diagnostic toolkit for identifying expressive content in specific cases.

For this purpose, Potts (2007) proposes a set of criteria that more sharply delineate expressive meaning, including independence from truth-conditional content, nondisplaceability, and speaker-oriented perspective dependence, among others (to be discussed in more detail in Section 3.2). These diagnostics have since become a standard testing ground for identifying expressive content across different domains.

- (12) a. That bastard Kresge is famous.
 b. Kresge is famous.

While both utterances share the same truth-conditional content, only (12a) contains an additional expressive component reflecting the speaker's negative attitude. Crucially, this component behaves differently from descriptive content, motivating the need for dedicated diagnostics.

In what follows, we adopt the Pottsonian criteria as a diagnostic toolkit and apply them to the domain of speech-accompanying gesture. In

particular, we build on Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025), who systematically apply these diagnostics to iconic and emblematic gestures and argue that emblematic gestures—but crucially not iconic gestures—pattern with spoken-language expressives, as they meet all Pottsonian criteria. In line with the assumptions laid out above, we will initially focus on *lexicalized* gesture types, i.e., emblematic gestures, which are the most natural candidates for expressive meaning due to their conventionalized form–meaning mappings. At the same time, we will briefly return to the question of whether iconic gestures may also exhibit expressive properties in the last part (Section 5). The next section therefore first introduces the Pottsonian criteria in detail and then applies them to emblems to test for the hypothesis that they constitute expressive meaning.

3.2 Detecting expressivity: The Pottsonian diagnostics

Since Kaplan (1999), expressive meaning has received sustained attention in formal semantics and pragmatics (Gutzmann, 2012; Potts, 2005, 2007; Rett, 2021, i.a.). A central proposal emerging from this line of work is that expressive content differs systematically from descriptive content and can be identified via a set of diagnostics. Building on earlier work, Potts (2007) proposes a cluster of criteria that characterize expressive meaning, including *independence*, *nondisplaceability*, *perspective dependence*, *descriptive ineffability*, *immediacy*, and *repeatability*. In what follows, we apply these diagnostics to emblematic gestures. We restrict our discussion to this gesture type because emblematic gestures are conventionalized and lexicalized in a way that makes them plausible candidates for expressive meaning in the strict sense. By contrast, iconic gestures are not lexicalized to the same degree and, on our view, are therefore not expressive in this narrower sense. We refer the interested reader to Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) for a more detailed discussion of why iconic gestures fail to satisfy most of the relevant criteria.

Independence relates to the property that expressive content contributes meaning in a dimension separate from truth-conditional

content. On Potts’s view, this predicts that expressive content cannot be straightforwardly targeted by direct denial.

- (13) a. A: That bastard Kresge is famous.
 b. B₁: No, he’s not that famous.
 c. B₂: #No, he’s not a bastard.

As Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) note, the situation is somewhat mixed for emblematic gestures. Co-speech emblems can, at least in some cases, pattern with not-at-issue content, but this is less clear-cut than in the spoken case. This is illustrated by the co-speech THUMBS UP example in (14), where direct denial appears better than in the corresponding iconic cases they discuss, though still not fully natural.

- (14) a. A: I went to [the cinema] yesterday.
 THUMBS UP
 b. C: ?That’s not true! You told me earlier that day that you didn’t like the movie.

At the same time, not all co-speech emblems behave alike. As argued in Esipova (2019b), CRAZY⁵ (cf. Figure 0.3) and FINGERS CROSSED appear to project and thus behave more like not-at-issue material, whereas AIR QUOTES contributes at-issue content.

- (15) If you bring a [semanticist] to my talk, I’ll likely fight with
 CRAZY
 them.
 → If you bring a semanticist to my talk, I’ll likely fight with them.
 → All semanticists are crazy.

⁵Unlike Esipova (2019b), we are using the version of the CRAZY gesture that is most popular in German-speaking countries.



Figure 0.3: The CRAZY gesture.

- (16) a. If a friend of mine [wins the race], I'll buy them a drink.
FINGERS CROSSED
- b. If a friend of mine, {hopefully, fingers crossed}, wins the race, I'll buy them a drink.
- (17) a. Kim is bringing her [friend] to the party.
AIR QUOTES
- b. Kim is bringing her so-called friend to the party.

Taken together, these data suggest that the independence criterion is the least clear-cut one for emblematic gestures. Still, at least some co-speech emblems can be not-at-issue, while pro- and post-speech emblems tend to behave more like asserted material.

Nondisplaceability captures the observation that expressives are typically anchored to the utterance situation. They may occur in sentences about past events, but their affective contribution is still interpreted relative to the speaker's current attitude rather than as merely reporting a past emotion.

- (18) Two days ago, I spilled fucking red wine over my new pair of white jeans.

This property appears to hold for emblematic gestures as well. The co-speech emblematic gestures in (19)–(21) are naturally understood as conveying attitudes that still hold at utterance time.

- (19) Two days ago I saw a [movie].
THUMBS UP

- (20) Last week, Peter brought his [friend] Jonah to the party.
AIR QUOTES

- (21) At the conference last month, there were many [semanticists].
CRAZY

In all of these cases, the gesture's contribution is most naturally interpreted as anchored to the speaker's mental attitude in the current utterance situation. This also extends to pro-speech uses, which are especially important for emblematic gestures because they frequently occur as stand-alone communicative acts.

- (22) a. A: How did you like the movie?
b. B: []
THUMBS UP

Here, the gesture does not merely report a past positive reaction, but indicates that the speaker is still in a positively charged state with respect to the movie in the utterance situation. As in the spoken domain, the affective target of the emblem need not always coincide with the element it aligns with. Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) make this point with the CRAZY gesture in (23) and (24).

- (23) (Context: We can't come to the movies.)
 My sister has to [mow the lawn].
 CRAZY

- (24) My [sister] has to mow the lawn.
 CRAZY

As these contrasts suggest, alignment can affect what the attitude is directed at, much like argument extension effects with spoken expressives.

Perspective dependence refers to the fact that expressives are normally interpreted from the speaker's perspective. Although shifts are possible, they are marked and context-dependent.

- (25) My father screamed that he would never allow me to marry that bastard Webster.

Emblematic gestures pattern similarly. In the pro-speech THUMBS UP example above, the positive attitude must be understood as the speaker's. The same holds for the co-speech THUMBS UP in the movie example and for AIR QUOTES in (26).

- (26) Last week, Peter brought his [friend] Jonah to the party.
 AIR QUOTES

Likewise, the most natural interpretation of the CRAZY gesture in (27) is that it reflects the speaker's perspective, not Sarah's.

- (27) At the conference last month, Sarah saw many [semanticists].
 CRAZY
 (Esipova, 2019b)

relevant affective stance in the utterance situation. As Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) further note, some highly offensive emblems are in this respect even “toxic,” much like certain spoken expressives (cf. Nunberg, 2013).

Repeatability refers to the fact that repetition often strengthens expressive meaning rather than resulting in mere redundancy.

- (31) a. Fuck, I forgot my wallet in the office again.
 b. Fuck, I forgot my fucking wallet in the office again.
 c. Fuck, I forgot my fucking wallet in the fucking office again.

Although this criterion is not uncontroversial, emblematic gestures appear to pattern with spoken expressives here as well. Repeated instances of offensive gestures such as MIDDLE FINGER or CRAZY, and also of positively connotated gestures such as THUMBS UP, can produce an emphatic strengthening effect. Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) illustrate this with the example in (32).

- (32) [I] [really] [hate] [this] [idiot].
 5 × MIDDLE FINGER (each aligned with one word)

This is unlike the repetition of iconic gestures, which tends to yield either infelicity or a changed descriptive interpretation rather than expressive strengthening.

Taken together, Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025) conclude that the Pottsonian diagnostics strongly support the view that emblematic gestures pattern with spoken-language expressives. The one partially problematic criterion is independence, since co-speech emblems do not behave uniformly and alignment matters. Even so, once one considers the full cluster of diagnostics, the overall picture is clear: emblematic gestures, especially highly lexicalized ones and especially in frequent pro-speech uses, are best analyzed as visual expressives.

At this point, one might be tempted to conclude that emblematic gestures form a uniform semantic class and can thus straightforwardly be assimilated to interjections, as suggested in the descriptive literature (e.g., Kendon, 1988; Poggi, 1983, 1987). After all, the preceding discussion has shown that emblematic gestures robustly satisfy the Pottisian diagnostics for expressivity and, at least at first glance, appear to pattern with canonical expressive items such as interjections. On such a view, a uniform analysis of emblems as interjection-like expressives would seem both natural and theoretically attractive.

However, a closer look at the data reveals that this picture is overly simplistic. As we will show next, emblematic gestures do not behave uniformly with respect to key properties that distinguish different types of use-conditional meaning. In particular, while some emblems behave in ways that closely resemble interjections, others exhibit properties that set them apart in systematic ways. Crucially, we do not find any emblematic gestures that fully replicate the behavior of canonical interjections across the relevant diagnostics. Instead, the empirical landscape suggests a more fine-grained typology, in which different subclasses of emblems occupy distinct positions within the space of expressive meaning, or use-conditional meaning more broadly (Gutzmann, 2015). This motivates the need for a more articulated analysis, to which we now turn.

3.3 Further observations: Two types of expressive emblems?!

A particularly revealing domain in which emblematic gestures diverge concerns their behavior under embedding, and in particular their shifting properties in indirect discourse. While expressive items are canonically assumed to resist perspective shift, the data discussed in the preceding section already suggest that emblematic gestures do not behave uniformly in this respect.

Consider first emblems such as THUMBS UP, which we will henceforth frequently call Type I-emblems. When used in matrix contexts, these gestures straightforwardly express a positive attitude of the speaker. Crucially, however, when embedded under an attitude predicate, their

interpretation becomes more flexible. In co-speech position, THUMBS UP can give rise to a shifted interpretation, where the attitude is plausibly attributed to the attitude holder rather than the speaker.

- (33) Paul said Peter was [dancing].
THUMBS UP
 → speaker-oriented
 → shifted (Paul-oriented)

At the same time, this shiftability is not uniform across all positions. In pre- and post-speech uses, THUMBS UP strongly favors a speaker-oriented interpretation, suggesting that gesture-speech alignment plays a crucial role in licensing perspective shift.

By contrast, other emblems such as CRAZY (henceforth often called Type II-emblems) behave markedly differently. Even in embedded environments, they resist perspective shift and are robustly interpreted from the speaker's perspective. Strictly speaking, they behave more parallel to spoken-language expressives in this regard as emblems like THUMBS UP do.

- (34) Paul said Peter was [dancing].
CRAZY
→ speaker-oriented
 $\nrightarrow$ shifted (Paul-oriented)

This contrast is particularly striking given that both gesture types satisfy the standard diagnostics for expressive meaning. It therefore cannot be reduced to a simple expressive vs. non-expressive distinction. Instead, it points to a deeper difference in how these gestures interact with the compositional structure of the utterance.

Further evidence for this divide comes from distributional differences. Type I-emblems can occur felicitously in isolation, for instance as standalone responses to questions, suggesting that their meaning contribution does not depend on a specific linguistic anchor.

(35) a. A: Did you like the movie?

b. B: []
 THUMBS UP

In contrast, Type II-emblems are degraded in such uses and strongly prefer co-speech realization, where they align with and modify a specific constituent.

(36) a. A: What did you think of Peter?

b. B: #[?][]
 CRAZY

Taken together, the data suggest that emblematic gestures fall into (at least) two distinct classes. One class, exemplified by THUMBS UP, exhibits a high degree of independence from the linguistic signal, allows for limited perspective shift under embedding, and can occur as a standalone communicative act. Another class, exemplified by CRAZY, at least at first glance, seems to interact stronger with the surrounding speech material, resists perspective shift, and depends on alignment with a linguistic argument.

These differences are unexpected under a uniform treatment of emblematic gestures as interjections. While some emblems come close to interjection-like behavior, others clearly do not. At the same time, even the most interjection-like emblems diverge from canonical interjections, for instance in their relative ease of shifting under embedding. The emerging picture is therefore one in which emblematic gestures systematically occupy different positions within the space of expressive meaning, rather than forming a homogeneous class.

In the next section, we develop a formal account of this variation by arguing that these two classes correspond to different types of use-conditional items.

4 Formal analysis

The observations from the previous section suggest that emblematic gestures do not form a semantically homogeneous class. While all emblems discussed above qualify as expressive in the sense of Potts (2007), they nevertheless differ systematically in their interaction with truth-conditional content, their degree of integration into linguistic structure, and their behavior under embedding.

In particular, we observed two central contrasts. First, some emblems such as THUMBS UP can occur independently of speech and do not appear to require an argument from the at-issue content. Others, such as CRAZY, strongly prefer co-speech realization and intuitively modify the constituent they align with. Second, these gesture types differ with respect to perspective shift in embedded environments: while THUMBS UP allows comparatively easy shifted interpretations, CRAZY strongly favors speaker-oriented interpretations also under embedding.

We propose that these differences reflect a deeper distinction between two subclasses of use-conditional items (UCIs) in the sense of Gutzmann (2012, 2015). More specifically, we argue that some emblematic gestures pattern with *isolated expletive UCIs*, whereas others behave more like *functional expletive UCIs*.⁶ To formally capture this distinction, we adopt $\mathcal{L}_{TU}$ (Gutzmann, 2015).

$\mathcal{L}_{TU}$ is a hybrid, multidimensional logic designed to capture the interaction between truth-conditional and use-conditional meaning. Its central motivation is that certain expressions contribute not to the truth conditions of an utterance, but to its conditions of felicitous use. In $\mathcal{L}_{TU}$, such use-conditional content is represented as propositions over contexts rather than worlds. More specifically, these *u-propositions* are sets of contexts in which an expression can be felicitously used (cf. (41) and (48) below).

⁶Interestingly, face emoji have also been argued to make expressive contributions (Grosz, 2025). However, they seem to behave more uniform than emblems do, as only occurrences as isolated expletive UCIs have been attested thus far.

Importantly, lexical entries themselves are not assumed to be fully three-dimensional from the outset. Under Gutzmann’s L^2 *hypothesis*, lexical items can have at most one truth-conditional and one use-conditional component (Gutzmann, 2015, p. 144). Items that contain both components are mixed items. Since the present analysis is concerned only with expletive UCIs, we set mixed items aside here.

The three-dimensional structure of $\mathcal{L}_{TU}$ arises only once lexical expressions are translated into the object language and subsequently expanded by lexical extension rules. These rules add missing dimensions in order to make expressions compositionally combinable throughout the derivation. The resulting representations contain three dimensions: the *t*-dimension, which stores truth-conditional content; the *s*-dimension, which stores unsaturated use-conditional content, i.e., content that is still available for the calculation of use-conditional meaning; and the *u*-dimension, which stores saturated use-conditional content. The *t*- and *u*-dimensions thus correspond roughly to the at-issue and CI-dimensions in Potts (2005), respectively, while the *s*-dimension corresponds to the shunting types proposed by McCready (2010).

4.1 Isolated expletive UCIs

Canonical examples of isolated expletive UCIs are interjections.

- (37) a. Ouch! I hit my thumb.
 b. Fuck!

As discussed by Gutzmann (2015), such expressions do not interact compositionally with truth-conditional content. They occur in peripheral positions, do not take arguments from descriptive material, and can stand alone and express independent speech acts.

We argue that emblematic gestures such as THUMBS UP instantiate the visual counterpart of this expressive type.

- (38) Peter [is dancing].
 THUMBS UP

Crucially, the gesture does not necessarily modify the aligned constituent. Instead, it contributes information that the *contextual judge* (cf. Lasersohn, 2005, more detail below) is in a positive mental state. This also explains why THUMBS UP can occur felicitously in pre- and post-speech position without substantial meaning change.

- (39) a. [] Peter is dancing.
 THUMBS UP
- b. Peter is dancing. []
 THUMBS UP

Unlike canonical interjections, however, these gestures can occur under embedding and allow comparatively easy shifted interpretations (cf. the discussion in Section 3.3 of this contribution).

- (40) Paul said Peter [was dancing].
 THUMBS UP

As discussed in the previous section, the most accessible interpretation is often one in which the positive attitude is attributed to the reported speaker rather than the current utterance speaker. In a similar vein, previous research has found that other types of use-conditional content can receive non-speaker-oriented interpretations in indirect discourse, as well (Harris and Potts, 2009). However, non-speaker-oriented interpretations seem to be a default property of emblems of the THUMBS UP-type rather than an exception, although experimental validation for this is still pending. For now, however, we propose to capture this intuition by relativizing the use conditions of these gestures not toward the current speaker, but making them judge-dependent instead (Lasersohn, 2005).

The use conditions of THUMBS UP can therefore be stated as follows. The natural-language gesture THUMBS UP is first translated into an expression **thumbs up** of $\mathcal{L}_{TU}$ of type u . Since it is already saturated, it denotes a u -proposition, i.e., a set of contexts in which the gesture can be felicitously used.

- (41) THUMBS UP is felicitous in a world w and a context c iff
 $c \in \{c : \text{judge}_c \text{ is in a positive mental state in } w_c\}$

The crucial difference from canonical interjections thus lies in the replacement of speaker dependence with judge dependence. This preserves the strong perspectival component characteristic of expressives while simultaneously accounting for the comparatively flexible shifting behavior of emblematic gestures in indirect discourse.

Since **thumbs up** only has content in the u -dimension, a lexical extension rule applies in order to make the expression fully three-dimensional for purposes of composition. This yields the following extended entry:

- (42) THUMBS UP: $u \Rightarrow T \diamond T \bullet \text{thumbs up} : u$

Here, $\diamond$ separates the t - from the s -dimension, while $\bullet$ separates the s - from the u -dimension. The notation thus allows dimensions to be represented explicitly even when they contain only trivial placeholder content. The lexical extension rule inserts the trivial truth-conditional object T into the t -dimension, whose interpretation is the set W of all possible worlds. In other words, T is true in every world $w \in W$. A copy of this trivial content is additionally stored in the s -dimension. The material added by the lexical extension rule therefore merely serves compositional purposes and does not itself contribute informative truth-conditional or use-conditional content.

Interpretation in $\mathcal{L}_{TU}$ proceeds via a three-dimensional interpretation function $\|\cdot\|$, which assigns an expression A a triple of interpretation functions (cf. (43)). The individual dimensions can then be accessed

via $\|A\|^t$, $\|A\|^s$, and $\|A\|^u$, respectively. Formally, these correspond to $\pi_1\|A\|$, $\pi_2\|A\|$, and $\pi_3\|A\|$, i.e., the first, second, and third member of the interpretation triple.

A sentence S is true in a world w and a context c iff $w \in \|S\|^t$. It is felicitous iff $c \in \|S\|^u$. The s -dimension, by contrast, merely serves as an intermediate representational layer during composition and does not directly determine either truth or use conditions.

Sentence interpretation therefore yields the following three-dimensional representation:

$$(43) \quad \begin{array}{l} \|\text{Peter [is dancing]}\| = \\ \quad \text{THUMBS UP} \\ \langle \llbracket \text{dance}(\text{peter}) \rrbracket, \llbracket \text{dance}(\text{peter}) \rrbracket, \llbracket \text{thumbs up} \rrbracket \rangle \end{array}$$

The sentence is truth-conditionally true iff Peter is dancing, while the use conditions additionally require that the contextual judge is in a positive mental state.

4.2 Functional expletive UCIs

A further class discussed by Gutzmann (2015) are functional expletive UCIs. Unlike isolated expletives, these expressions are compositionally integrated and take an argument from the truth-conditional dimension. Canonical examples are expressive adjectives.

- (44) a. That damn printer is broken again.
 b. I lost my fucking keys.

These expressions contribute expressive meaning while simultaneously modifying descriptive content. Unlike interjections, they cannot normally occur independently.

We argue that gestures such as CRAZY belong to this second expressive type.

- (45) [Peter] is dancing.
CRAZY

Unlike THUMBS UP, the gesture here intuitively modifies the aligned constituent and expresses that the speaker has a negative attitude toward Peter. This also explains why pre- and post-speech realizations are strongly degraded.

- (46) a. #[?][] Peter is dancing.
CRAZY
- b. Peter is dancing. #[?][]⁷
CRAZY

Furthermore, these gestures strongly resist shifted interpretations under embedding.

- (47) Paul said [Peter] was dancing.
CRAZY

The preferred interpretation remains one in which the negative attitude is attributed to the current speaker.

We therefore model these gestures analogously to expressive adjectives. Their use conditions are speaker-dependent, as non-speaker-oriented interpretations seem to be the exception rather than the standard, and require an argument from the truth-conditional dimension.

As before, the natural-language gesture CRAZY is first translated into an expression **crazy** of $\mathcal{L}_{TV}$. Unlike **thumbs up**, however, **crazy** is not already saturated. Rather, it is of type $\langle e, u \rangle$: it requires

⁷As Elsi Kaiser (p.c.) noted, (46b) is intuitively less degraded than (46a). She attributed this to a potential cause–effect interpretation being available for the former but not the latter example. We leave a closer investigation of this to future research.

an individual argument before it can yield saturated use-conditional content.

- (48) CRAZY is felicitous in a world w and a context c iff
 $c \in \{c : \text{speaker}_c \text{ has a negative attitude toward Peter in } w_c\}$

The lexical extension rule for functional expletive UCIs then yields the extended lexical entry in (49):

- (49) CRAZY: $\langle e, u \rangle \Rightarrow I_e \diamond \mathbf{crazy}: \langle e, u \rangle \bullet U$

Unlike isolated expletive UCIs, the expressive content is initially stored in the s -dimension. It therefore remains unsaturated until it combines with an argument of type e from the truth-conditional dimension and is then transferred to the u -dimension by means of a lexical elimination rule. The u -dimension contains only a neutral use-conditional placeholder U , which can be used in all contexts and therefore contributes no informative use conditions at this stage.

The t -dimension contains an identity function I_e . This function returns its individual argument unchanged and thereby ensures that the truth-conditional content is preserved rather than being fully shunted into the s -dimension. In the present discussion, we restrict attention to cases in which the gesture takes an individual argument. This is sufficient for examples such as CRAZY modifying *Peter*. Cases in which expressive visual material appears to comment on larger constituents, including entire propositions, require additional assumptions; see Grosz (2025) for relevant discussion in the domain of emoji that are compatible with the account sketched here.

Sentence interpretation then yields:

- (50) $\llbracket [\text{Peter}] \text{ is dancing.} \rrbracket =$
 CRAZY
 $\langle \llbracket \mathbf{dance}(\mathbf{peter}) \rrbracket, \llbracket \mathbf{dance}(\mathbf{peter}) \rrbracket, \llbracket \mathbf{crazy}(\mathbf{peter}) \rrbracket \rangle$

The sentence is truth-conditionally true iff Peter is dancing, while the use conditions additionally require that the speaker has a negative attitude toward Peter.

The central difference between the two gesture classes therefore does not concern whether they contribute expressive meaning, but rather how this meaning is compositionally integrated into the utterance. Whereas Type I-emblems contribute independent saturated use conditions, Type II-emblems compositionally interact with truth-conditional material before yielding expressive content.

5 Conclusion and outlook

This paper has argued that emblematic gestures constitute a distinct class of expressive meaning contributions in the visual modality of spoken language. Building on the observation that emblems differ from iconic gestures in their degree of conventionalization, lexical stability, and independence from the surrounding speech signal, we first showed that emblematic gestures are natural candidates for an expressive analysis, following Cornelia Ebert and Walter (2025). Unlike iconic gestures, whose interpretation is typically underspecified and depends strongly on the co-occurring speech signal, emblems such as THUMBS UP, CRAZY, or the MIDDLE FINGER have relatively stable meanings and can realize entire speech acts on their own.

We then applied the Pottsian diagnostics for expressive meaning to emblematic gestures. The resulting picture supports the claim that emblematic gestures pattern with spoken-language expressives: they are nondisplaceable, perspective-dependent, descriptively ineffable, immediate, and repeatable in the relevant sense. The independence criterion turned out to be more complex, since the at-issue status of emblematic gestures is sensitive to alignment and differs across individual emblems. Nevertheless, the overall cluster of diagnostics supports the view that emblematic gestures should be treated as visual expressives.

At the same time, the paper has shown that emblematic gestures do not form a semantically homogeneous class. Some emblems, such as THUMBS UP, can occur independently of speech rather easily, do not require an argument from truth-conditional content, and allow comparatively flexible shifted interpretations under embedding. Other emblems, such as CRAZY, are more tightly integrated with the surrounding linguistic material, require an argument, and strongly favor speaker-oriented interpretations. We proposed to capture this contrast by analyzing the former as isolated expletive UCIs and the latter as functional expletive UCIs in the sense of Gutzmann (2015).

The formal analysis developed in Section 4 implements this distinction in $\mathcal{L}_{TU}$. Type I-emblems contribute saturated use-conditional content directly in the u -dimension. Type II-emblems, by contrast, initially contribute unsaturated use-conditional content in the s -dimension and must combine with an argument from the truth-conditional dimension before yielding a saturated use condition. The difference between the two types is therefore not whether they are expressive, but how their expressive meaning is compositionally integrated into the utterance.

While the formal analysis proposed in this paper is to the best of our knowledge the first systematic formal-semantic account for emblematic gestures, several questions remain open and provide promising directions for future research. First, the present contribution has focused on expressivity in the narrow sense of Gutzmann and Turgay (2025), that is, on cases in which expressive meaning is conventionally encoded and part of a lexical entry. This restriction naturally raises the question of whether expressive effects can also arise in gesture types that are not fully lexicalized and conventionalized, in particular iconic gestures.

A particularly interesting case is discussed in Schlenker (2019), namely the EFFEMINATE HAND gesture illustrated in Figure 0.4. In a pro-speech use such as in (51), the gesture can give rise to a strongly expressive interpretation roughly paraphrasable as *I won't hire a faggot*.

A second issue concerns the internal structure of emblematic gestures themselves. Research on emblems has traditionally focused predominantly on handshape, often treating it as the primary carrier of meaning. However, the contrast in Figure 0.5 suggests that this perspective may be too narrow.

Both gestures involve the same basic handshape, namely tapping on the temple, but differ substantially in interpretation depending on accompanying facial expression and overall performance. One yields a negative expressive interpretation (CRAZY), whereas the other conveys a positive evaluation (SMART). Importantly, however, the two interpretations do not appear entirely arbitrary. Rather, they remain semantically related in a systematic way: both gestures convey an expressive attitude of the speaker toward another person's cognitive abilities or mental state.

This is particularly intriguing because the gestures discussed here are emblematic rather than merely iconic. One might therefore expect their meaning to be fully conventionalized and detached from depictive structure, yet the data suggest that an iconic semantic core remains active even in these lexicalized gestures. Intuitively, the shared handshape contributes a schematic meaning component related to cognition or mental capacity via the iconic act of tapping one's temple, while facial expression and other properties modulate the resulting expressive interpretation toward either a positive or negative direction.



Figure 0.5: Different interpretations associated with the same handshape.

If this intuition is on the right track, emblematic gestures may not consist of entirely arbitrary form–meaning pairings after all. Instead, at least some emblems may combine lexicalized expressive meaning with residual iconic structure that continues to play an active role in semantic interpretation. This raises the broader question whether apparently distinct emblems could ultimately be reduced to more abstract underlying lexical representations that are systematically enriched by iconic information during interpretation.

A third open question concerns the boundary between evaluativity and expressivity. Some gestures appear to be conventionalized and lexically stable without straightforwardly contributing expressive meaning in the strong sense discussed throughout this paper. Consider, for example, the DRINKING gesture in Figure 0.6.

Interestingly, the DRINKING gesture appears flexible between neutral and evaluative interpretations depending on its mode of use. Consider first the standalone pro-speech use in (52). Imagine a context in which the speaker is engaged in a conversation in a crowded room, notices a friend on the other side of the room, and produces the gesture non-verbally toward them.

- (52) Context: The speaker is engaged in a conversation in a crowded room and notices a friend on the other side of the room.

[]
DRINKING



Figure 0.6: The DRINKING gesture.

In this case, the gesture naturally receives a comparatively neutral interpretation roughly paraphrasable as *Bring me something to drink*. The gesture here functions as a standalone communicative act without necessarily conveying an expressive or evaluative attitude.

By contrast, when the same gesture occurs as a word-replacing prospeech gesture inside a sentence, a much stronger evaluative interpretation arises:

- (53) You know John, right? Rumor has it he's got a bit of a
 [].
 DRINKING

Here, the gesture strongly invites the inference that John has a drinking problem or drinks excessively. Importantly, in this particular context, an evaluative interpretation appears to be essentially the only plausible one. A neutral interpretation merely conveying that John drinks alcohol is strongly dispreferred. One possible explanation is that the gesture itself only conventionally encodes a comparatively neutral meaning related to drinking, while the evaluative interpretation arises pragmatically. More specifically, the evaluative effect may constitute a conversational implicature in the Gricean sense (Grice, 1975). Since the speaker chose to express the information via gesture rather than via a lexical alternative such as *drinking problem*, interlocutors infer that there must be a communicatively relevant reason for this marked choice. The resulting interpretation is therefore not necessarily expressive in the narrow semantic sense, but may instead arise from pragmatic reasoning about the speaker's communicative intentions. Clarifying the boundary between genuinely expressive meaning and evaluative pragmatic inference therefore constitutes another important topic for future work.

More generally, the present contribution has exclusively focused on visual expressives in spoken language. A systematic comparison with expressive devices in sign languages therefore remains an important desideratum. Such a comparison may also help sharpen the distinction between expressivity and evaluativity discussed above, since sign

languages provide a rich domain in which lexicalization, iconicity, facial expression, and expressive meaning interact in highly systematic ways. More broadly, future work should investigate to what extent expressive meaning is modality-independent and whether the typology of use-conditional items proposed for spoken language can be generalized across modalities.

Taken together, the observations discussed throughout this paper suggest that expressive meaning is not tied to the spoken modality alone, but constitutes a more general phenomenon that can also be systematically encoded in the visual modality of spoken language. Emblematic gestures therefore provide an important testing ground for theories of multidimensional meaning and use-conditional semantics, while at the same time revealing that iconicity, conventionalization, and expressivity interact in more intricate ways than has commonly been assumed.

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